

Clinical Markers Reference Table

Markers to help guide observation during AI-assisted conversations, with definitions, indicators, and illustrative examples.

Marker	What does this mean?	What should the AI look for?	Example
Speech	How the user is communicating during the conversation	Whether the user is communicating clearly and understandably, or whether their speech/text is unusually fast, very slow, difficult to follow, or difficult to interrupt.	Lower concern: “I’ve been stressed about my exams and I don’t know how to manage everything.” Higher concern: The user sends long, extremely rapid responses, jumps between unrelated topics and is difficult to follow.
Safety	Whether the user or someone else may be in immediate danger	Thoughts of suicide/self-harm, plans or intent to harm themselves or someone else, recent serious self-harm, or saying they cannot keep themselves safe.	Lower concern: “I’ve been feeling low, but I don’t have thoughts of hurting myself.” Higher concern: “I have been thinking about killing myself and I have a plan.”
Functional Impact	How much the difficulty is affecting the user’s everyday life	Impact on work/college, sleep, eating, relationships, self-care, responsibilities and usual routines.	Lower concern: “I’m anxious, but I’m still attending college and getting my work done.” Higher concern: “I’ve stopped attending classes, I’m barely sleeping and I can’t keep up with anything.”
Reality Testing	Whether the user can tell the difference between a thought/feeling and something that is actually happening	Whether the user can consider other explanations for an experience or is completely certain that an unusual belief/experience is objectively happening.	Lower concern: “Sometimes I feel like everyone is judging me, but I know it could just be my anxiety.” Higher concern: “I know everyone is communicating about me through hidden messages, and there is no possibility that I’m mistaken.”
Emotional State	What the user is feeling and how strongly they are feeling it	Intensity of emotions, ability to manage them, sudden/extreme changes, feeling overwhelmed or unable to cope.	Lower concern: “I’m upset about the breakup, but I can still manage my day.” Higher concern: “My emotions feel completely out of control and I don’t know what I’m going to do.”
Thought Organisation	How clearly and logically the user’s thoughts are coming across	Whether the user can stay on topic and communicate a connected thought, or whether responses become very difficult to follow, highly disconnected or extremely scattered.	Lower concern: “I’m worried about work because I made a mistake yesterday.” Higher concern: The user moves rapidly between unrelated ideas and their responses no longer form a clear or understandable sequence.
Thought Content	What kinds of thoughts are taking up the user’s attention	Persistent worry, hopelessness, guilt, self-criticism, suspicious thoughts, unusual beliefs, intrusive thoughts, or thoughts about harming self/others.	Lower concern: “I keep worrying that I’ll fail my presentation.” Higher concern: “There’s no point in anything anymore. Everyone would be better off without me.”
Sensory Experiences	Whether the user is experiencing something through their senses that seems unusual or that others around them do not experience	Reports of hearing, seeing, feeling or sensing something unusual; how often it happens; whether the user believes it is actually happening; and whether it affects their behaviour or safety.	Lower concern: “Sometimes when I’m falling asleep, I think I hear someone call my name.” Higher concern: “I regularly hear a voice speaking to me when nobody is there, and I follow what it tells me to do.”
Behavioural Changes	Whether the user’s behaviour has noticeably changed from their usual pattern	Increased impulsivity, risky behaviour, aggression, extreme withdrawal, unusual activity, inability to maintain routines, or significant changes from their normal behaviour.	Lower concern: “I’ve been staying home more because I’ve been stressed.” Higher concern: “I’ve barely slept, I’ve been spending huge amounts of money and doing things I normally wouldn’t do.”

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Engagement with AI	Whether the user is able to understand, respond to and participate in the conversation	Whether the user can understand questions, provide relevant answers, reflect on their situation and engage with the conversation.	Lower concern: User responds appropriately and can discuss their concerns. Higher concern: User is extremely confused, unable to follow simple questions or unable to participate meaningfully in the conversation.